I N T R O D U C T I O N

The ceremony marking the change of command of the Mossad, during which I received my letter of appointment, took place on April 19, 1989, at the Prime Minister's Office in Jerusalem. Among those present were Prime Minister Yitzhak Shamir, who had chosen me to serve as director of the Mossad; minister of defense and former prime minister Yitzhak Rabin; Israel Defense Forces (IDF) chief of staff Dan Shomron; former Mossad directors; the Mossad Division Heads' Forum (Rasha); the Heads of Services Committee (Varash); the military secretary to the prime minister; the prime minister's veteran stenographer Mitka Yaffe; the outgoing Mossad director Nahum Admoni and his family; and my own family, with the exception of my youngest son, who was off skiing in Switzerland.

The ceremony was modest and conducted with an air of understatement characteristic of Prime Minister Shamir. The prime minister read out Nahum's letter marking the end of his tenure and thanked him briefly for his service and for his long-standing contribution to Israel's national security. Nahum delivered some parting words. The prime minister read out my letter of appointment and wished me good luck in the new position. I then gave my prepared remarks, to which I had given a great deal of thought.

I began by mentioning my twenty-five years of service in the Mossad, which I believed had trained me for the esteemed role that I was taking on. Even so, I accepted the role with apprehension, veneration, and trepidation. I thanked the prime minister for choosing me, and Nahum for warmly recommending me for the job. I thanked my family and especially my wife, who at the beginning of my career had partaken in covert activities along with me. I emphasized the great sacrifice required of the family members of Mossad operatives.